

SAF gains ground as a dual-use fuel

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Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By TOMMASO LECCA with JORDYN DAHL and MARTINA SAPIO SNEAK PEEK — Sustainable av

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure.

By TOMMASO LECCA

with JORDYN DAHL and MARTINA SAPIO

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SNEAK PEEK

— Sustainable aviation fuel could become a strategic alternative to fossil jet fuel, helping meet both civilian and military demand, representatives from NATO and the European Commission said.

— Brussels has money for the Western Balkans-Eastern Mediterranean corridor, but border delays and fragmented procedures risk blunting the impact.

— EV sales would stagnate by 2030 if the EPP's proposal for CO2 standards goes through, green NGO Transport & Environment argues in a new study.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

Tips to jdahl@politico.eu , tlecca@politico.eu and msapio@politico.eu . Follow us [@tommylecca](#) , [@jordyndahl](#) and [@martsapio](#) .

Mark your calendars: Our weekly mobility calendar landed in your inbox on Thursday. You can also go online to export and plan your week or suggest your own event.

DRIVING THE DAY

NATO, EU AIM TO ENLIST SAF AS DUAL-USE FUEL: Representatives from NATO and the European Commission said on Thursday that developing domestic production of sustainable aviation fuel could turn into a strategic priority to meet both civilian and military demand.

Just talks for now: Although the ReFuelEU mandates for SAF consumption are binding only for fuel producers and airlines, who remain skeptical of the EU targets, military and defense officials are now discussing how sustainable fuels could help prepare the bloc for a war scenario in which the demand for military jet fuel would skyrocket.

The Atlantic alliance is “actively pushing the certification of military platforms to be able to take alternative fuels,” said Julian Wieczorkiewicz, policy officer for operational energy at NATO, speaking at a conference organized by fuel producer Moeve and clean tech company Topsoe. He said that the alliance is in talks with energy ministries in order to build solutions that involve various departments and ministries across governments, he added, referring to the challenge of securing enough fuel to meet

both military and civilian demand during a major conflict.

Wartime scenario: Wierzchowicz cited a recent study by NATO's Energy Security Centre of Excellence showing that, in the event of war, aviation kerosene could account for 75% to 80% of the total military fuel mix, including gas and diesel, up from 60% to 72% in peacetime. Military demand for jet fuel would surge accordingly: "The military in Europe would need 45% of the current jet volumes supplied to the civilian domain," he said.

More defense, more demand: As European countries expand their military equipment, including fighter jets, the projected demand for military jet fuel during wartime could reach the equivalent of 65% of current consumption of civilian aviation by 2035, Wierzchowicz added, but he stressed that the study's estimates are "not official NATO numbers."

Watching wars: "Recent conflicts have reminded us of a fundamental importance of air power," said Tomasz Husak, director for defense policy at the Commission's DG DEFIS. Given the close links between Europe's civil and defense aerospace sectors, he asked: "Can we ensure that our armed forces continue to have access to the energy they require when supply chains are disrupted?"

Two birds, one stone: "Instead of building completely separate and civilian military ecosystems, we should identify where investments in infrastructural technologies and industrial capacity can reinforce both," Husak said, adding that "SAF is a very good example of this type of activity."

E-planes at war: Other clean aviation technologies could also have military applications. "Electric propulsion, for example, can reduce acoustic and infrared signatures," Husak said.

Energy security: "The EU still depends heavily on imported crude oil, especially for traditional kerosene aviation fuel," said Elena Scaltritti, CEO of Topsoe, a Danish clean energy company. "The answer lies in diversification," she added, calling for "building production capacity in Europe, developing reliable supplies of feedstocks and remaining open to importing SAF."

CARS

EXCLUSIVE — EPP CO2 PROPOSAL WOULD STALL EV SALES: If the European People's Party gets its way on weakening CO2 standards for cars, electric vehicle sales would stagnate by 2030, green NGO Transport & Environment argues in a report set to be released next week that was seen ahead of time by POLITICO.

Reminder: The EPP's proposed reform of the CO2 standards for automakers goes further than industry demands. Instead of a 90% emission reduction from 2021 levels — as the Commission is proposing, MEP Massimiliano Salini, the rapporteur on the file, wants the target to effectively be 73%, including offsets like investments in green steel or alternative fuels.

Fewer sales required: T&E's report says that under the EPP proposal, automakers could sell no electric vehicles starting in 2030 and still be compliant with the legislation. That's because hybrid vehicles and combustion engine vehicles running on alternative fuels like biofuels or e-fuels would also count toward the targets.

Save it for someone else: The NGO and some policymakers caution against using biofuels and e-fuels to power road transport when other sectors that are harder to decarbonize, like shipping and aviation, need the limited supply.

Would it matter? Electric vehicle sales are on the rise, buoyed by surging petrol prices courtesy of the war in Iran and new government subsidy programs like those in Germany and Italy. The latest data from car lobby ACEA shows EVs accounted for nearly 22% of the overall car market in August, up from about 16% at the same time last year.

Growing demand: Volkswagen is shifting production at its main plant in Wolfsburg from internal combustion engine vehicles to all-electric models. The automaker is “witnessing a significant turning point in the transformation of the automotive market,” a spokesperson told Jordyn in an email. “At the same time, we are seeing a corresponding decline in demand for vehicles with internal combustion engines.”

Supply problems: Stellantis, meanwhile, has had to put its electric vehicle manufacturing on hold because it does not have enough batteries to meet the demand. Its four factories in France will intermittently shut down this month because of the shortage.

PUMPING THE BREAKS ON THE 10% CLIFF EDGE: The European Commission is working to avoid a cliff edge that could add 10% tariffs on two-way trade with the U.K. over tightening rules of origin for EV batteries under the Brexit trade deal at the end of this year. The bloc’s trade chief Maroš Šefčovič told Britain’s Business and Trade Secretary Jonathan Reynolds the duties are in neither side’s interest, according to a British readout of their meeting on the margins of the G20 trade ministerial Wednesday.

Hey, we’re Made in Europe: Reynolds also “underlined that resolving ‘Made in Europe’ issues was important to both U.K. and EU interests,” the readout said, including discussions on automotive trade, steel and electric-vehicle batteries. Britain’s trade chief also “highlighted the value of integrated U.K.-EU automotive supply chains.”

CAN YOU BUILD A EUROPEAN CAR? You can give it a go with this video game created by the Socialists and Democrats to explain the Industrial Accelerator Act. Your mission: build a 100% European car, with deadlines, jobs, climate impact and geopolitical shocks thrown in.

TEN-T

WESTERN BALKANS CORRIDOR HITS THE BORDER BOTTLENECK: Brussels has money on the table for the Western Balkans-Eastern Mediterranean transport corridor, but officials and regional leaders warned at Connecting Europe Days that financing alone will not fix the network if border delays, fragmented procedures and weak project delivery remain unresolved.

Beyond concrete: Marian-Jean Marinescu, the European coordinator for the corridor, said the new work plan is meant to do more than guide construction, with implementing acts and high-level agreements intended to force progress on cross-border bottlenecks and interoperability.

EIB’s message: European Investment Bank Vice President Robert de Groot said the EIB remains ready to back major rail and road links across the region, but stressed that financing only works if projects are prepared and delivered efficiently. That chimes with what he told Martina separately in an interview , where he argued that member countries still have to initiate the projects, while the EIB can help shape them with its engineers, economists and technical staff once they are on the table.

Political push: Ministers from North Macedonia and Kosovo also called for faster delivery, better interoperability and more streamlined procedures, while DG ENEST warned that local governance, administrative capacity and procurement are still slowing projects down.

TRUCKS

DIESEL THREAT HITS EUROPE'S TRUCKERS: Donald Trump's threat to halt U.S. diesel exports could push up fuel costs for European hauliers already squeezed by record prices and tight margins — with knock-on effects for freight rates, supply chains and eventually consumer prices.

Background: Europe now relies heavily on U.S. diesel after disruptions cut supplies from Russia and the Middle East, leaving road freight particularly exposed. Industry figures warn prices around €3 per liter could trigger cash-flow problems, bankruptcies and reduced trucking capacity if the shock lasts.

Martina has more here .

MARITIME

RUSSIA DETENTION ADDS TO BALTIC SHIPPING RISK: Russia detained the Cyprus-flagged cargo ship Västernorrboten while it was heading for Estonia's Sillamäe port, adding another security headache for commercial shipping in the Gulf of Finland.

Why it matters: The vessel used a route through Russian territorial waters that Estonia, Finland and Russia had allowed because it is safer for large ships. Estonia says it has received no explanation for the detention.

Wider pattern: Russia had detained another vessel near Sillamäe in 2025, prompting Estonia to reroute ships through its own waters. The latest case reinforces the risk that wider Russian pressure in the Baltic increasingly spills into routine merchant shipping.

PIT STOPS

Ahead of negotiations on the ETS review, aviation lobby alliance Destination 2050 urged EU legislators to strengthen SAF allowances and maintain the current geographical scope of the carbon-pricing system.

Pegasus Airlines on Thursday announced the successful completion of its acquisition of Czech Airlines and Smartwings Group.

MEA CULPA: We incorrectly reported the U.K.'s car trade with the EU in Wednesday's newsletter. The U.K. will import around 520,000 electric vehicles from the EU next year.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

Trump's diesel threat risks hurting European truckers — and raising prices for consumers
Any U.S. diesel export ban could push European fuel prices even higher, with impacts across logistics and supply chains.

By Martina Sapio · Oct 01, 2026, 05:29 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Weekly Calendar

Here's a selection of upcoming key events, find the complete Week Ahead online.

ICAO Air Navigation World

Oct 5, 2026, 9:00 AM - Oct 9, 2026, 5:00 PM · Montreal, CA

Council Working Party on Land Transport

Oct 6, 2026 · Brussels, BE

POLITICO Pro Petit-Déjeuner – Budget 2027 : est-ce que ça va (vraiment) mal finir ?

Oct 6, 2026, 8:15 AM - 10:00 am

Health Summit 2026

Oct 6, 2026, 8:30 AM - 5:00 pm

Lanzamiento Oficial de Madrid Playbook

Oct 6, 2026, 7:00 PM - 11:00 pm

Council Working Party on Space (Attaché Trip)

Oct 7, 2026 - Oct 9, 2026 · Dublin, IE

Virtual Event from TEVA

Oct 7, 2026, 10:00 AM - 11:00 am

Eurogroup

Oct 8, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Pro Roundtable – Health Care

Oct 8, 2026, 8:15 AM - 9:45 am

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POLITICO Spotlight – Movin’On Summit 2026

Oct 9, 2026, 4:30 PM - 5:10 pm

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